

Promising as an Epistemic Practice

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Moorean promises—statements such as “I promise to ϕ , but I do not know whether I will ϕ ”—appear absurd. Beddor explains this absurdity by appealing to the Knowledge Norm of Promising. While his account captures the phenomenon, it does so at the cost of rendering many ordinary promises absurd as well, since we often lack knowledge of whether we will do what we promise. In this paper, I criticize this view and propose an alternative account of the absurdity of Moorean promises. I argue that promising itself brings about an epistemic improvement: once a promise is made, the promisor is in a better position to know that she will ϕ . On this basis, I explain the absurdity of Moorean promises in terms of the epistemic implications of the commitment involved in promising.

I. Introduction

Promises play a crucial role in our moral and social practices. By promising, we undertake obligations, generate expectations, and make ourselves accountable to others. Moorean promises, however—a specific kind of promise—appear puzzling. Such promises seem to involve a weak commitment, which makes them sound absurd, given that we ordinarily expect promises to involve strong commitment.

In Section II, I present an influential account of this phenomenon, traceable to Bob Beddor¹, which explains the absurdity of Moorean promises by appealing to the Knowledge Norm of Promising (KP). In Section III, I argue that KP fails as an adequate explanation of the phenomenon. I do so by examining three lines of critique: (1) KP cannot plausibly be treated as a necessary condition on promising; (2) nor can it be treated as a sufficient condition on promising; and (3) KP yields an implausible result by providing an excuse for promise-breaking.

Along the way, I highlight a principle according to which making a promise places the promisor in a better position to know that she will do what she promised. I argue that this epistemic improvement cannot be explained by KP. In Section IV, I defend this principle by offering a

¹ Beddor, Bob. “Moorean Promises,” *PhilArchive preprint*, 2024.

positive account of the reasons generated by promising and explain how promises improve the promisor's epistemic position.

In Section V, I show how this account explains the apparent absurdity of Moorean promises. I argue that Moorean promises are absurd because they involve an incoherent combination of undertaking an epistemic commitment and denying its characteristic epistemic improvement. Finally, in Section VI, I conclude by summarizing the main results and situating the contribution of the paper.

II. Knowledge as a Norm of Promising

A Moorean promise, such as “I promise to walk your dog while you're gone, but I do not know whether I will”, appears absurd, at least *prima facie*. Bob Beddor offers an influential explanation of this apparent absurdity by appealing to what he calls the Knowledge Norm of Promising (KP).

Knowledge Norm of Promising (KP): One ought not to promise to ϕ unless one knows that one will ϕ .²

Beddor's proposal is motivated by an analogy between promising and assertion. Just as assertion is commonly taken to be governed by an epistemic norm, promising, on Beddor's view, is subject to a parallel constraint. The corresponding norm for assertion is often formulated as follows:

Knowledge Norm of Assertion (KA): One Ought to assert p if one knows p .³

Beddor's argument for KP proceeds by appeal to a bridge principle connecting promising and assertion. His core argument for the apparent absurdity of Moorean promises is stated as follows:

- P1. Promise – Assertion Bridge: Anyone who is in a position to promise to ϕ is in a position to assert that they will ϕ .
- P2. KA: one is in a position to assert that one will ϕ only if one is in a position to know that one will ϕ .

² Beddor, “Moorean Promises,” p. 5.

³ *Ibid*, p. 4.

- C. Therefore, one is in a position to promise only if one is in a position to know that one will ϕ . (KP)

On this account, Moorean promises are absurd because they explicitly violate the epistemic norm required for appropriate promising. By promising to ϕ while simultaneously denying that one has knowledge that one will ϕ , the speaker represents herself as failing to satisfy a norm that governs the practice of promising. The apparent absurdity of Moorean promises is thus explained as a direct consequence of their incompatibility with the Knowledge Norm of Promising.

III. Rejecting KP

The Knowledge Norm of Promising (KP) purports to explain the absurdity of Moorean promises by imposing a knowledge requirement on appropriate promising. In this section, I argue that KP fails as an adequate norm of promising. I begin by challenging the Promise–Assertion Bridge (P1) in Beddor’s argument, which undermines KP as a necessary condition on promising. I then argue that KP also fails as a sufficient condition. Finally, I show that KP has the further implausible consequence of excusing promise-breaking.

I. *KP as a Necessary Condition*

KP relies on the Promise – Assertion Bridge, according to which one is in a position to promise to ϕ only if one is in a position to assert that one will ϕ . This bridge principle is implausible. One can be in a position to promise to ϕ while not being in a position to assert that one will ϕ . Consider a case in which an agent promises to quit smoking. Given the well-known difficulty of quitting, the agent may reasonably lack knowledge that she will succeed, despite sincerely intending to do so. Nevertheless, such a promise can be perfectly intelligible and valid. By contrast, assuming the Knowledge Norm of Assertion, the agent is not in a position to assert that she will quit, precisely because she lacks knowledge. This case shows that the epistemic standing required for promising can diverge from that required for assertion. Accordingly, KP cannot be a necessary condition on promising.

II. *KP as a Sufficient Condition*

One might respond to the previous objection by insisting that promises made without knowledge are irrational and therefore defective. However, this response has an implausible consequence: it would require us to treat a wide range of ordinary promises as irrational. Many of the promises we make in everyday life concern future actions whose successful completion we do not yet know.

Consider a familiar case. A parent promises to pick up her daughter from school. At the time of making the promise (t_0), the parent typically lacks knowledge that she will succeed, since unforeseen obstacles may arise. If asked at t_0 whether she knows that she will pick up her daughter, a natural response would be: *"I do not know yet, but I intend to."* However, if the same question is asked immediately after t_0 the answer would not be exactly the same, since it seems that in $t_0 + \epsilon$ the parent is more confident in having knowledge about doing what she promised. In this way, the promisor's epistemic status changes between t_0 and $t_0 + \epsilon$ (where $t_0 + \epsilon$ refers to the moment immediately after the promise is made). What the example is meant to show is that one is in a better position to know "I will ϕ " after promising than before. This motivates the following principle:

Epistemic Improvement of Promising: If one has promised, one then be in a better position to know about that one will ϕ .

In this manner, it can be the case that one is in a position to promise to ϕ while not being in a position to assert that one will ϕ . Moreover, one may be in a position to assert that one will ϕ after promising, even though one was not in a position to assert this before promising. For this reason, the Epistemic Improvement of Promising should be regarded as a genuine principle of promising, and any adequate account of promising should specify how it accommodates this principle. However, this does not entail that either one's epistemic position prior to promising (t_0) or one's position immediately after promising ($t_0 + \epsilon$) constitutes a position for having knowledge. I therefore argue next that the former position (t_0) cannot be a position of knowledge.

For this, consider again the case of picking up my daughter from school. If my daughter asks me, *"why will you pick me up?"*, the appropriate response is simply: *"Because I promised you."* The promise itself is what explains why I will ϕ , and nothing further is required.

However, according to KP, there must already be independent reasons sufficient to secure knowledge that I will act as promised. In that case, the promise appears redundant. On KP, the exchange would instead proceed as follows:

- *“I knew that I would pick you up from school”*
- *“How do you know that?”*
- *“For reasons independent of the promise”* (for example, *“I knew since my seer told me that I would do so”*)

This result is implausible. The promise itself should be the reason why the promisor will ϕ . If knowledge is already in place at the moment of promise-making, the promise loses its normative significance, since the promisor will ϕ independently of having promised. Under KP, promising thus collapses into mere reporting rather than genuine commitment.

So far, I have argued that our epistemic position after the moment of promise-making can be better than our position before. This motivates the following simple argument against KP:

- P1. Epistemic Improvement of Promising is a genuine principle.
- P2. Any adequate account of promising should accommodate this principle.
- P3. KP cannot accommodate this principle.

C. Therefore, KP should be rejected as an adequate norm of promising.

It is worth noting that I do not intend to deny that knowledge can play any role at the moment of promise-making. Rather, I just deny that knowledge constitutes the norm of promising, or that it is either a necessary or sufficient condition at the moment of promise-making. In the next section, I offer further support for the Epistemic Improvement of Promising principle.

III. Providing an excuse

KP has a further implausible consequence concerning broken promises. Suppose an agent promises to ϕ . There are two possible outcomes. First, the agent does what she promised. In this case, no difficulty arises. Second, the agent fails to do as promised. According to KP, this failure indicates that the agent never knew that she would ϕ at the time of promising. As a result, the promise fails to meet the epistemic condition required for valid promising. If this is right, then no genuine promise was made in the first place. The promisor merely misrepresented her epistemic state to the promisee. Promise-breaking is thereby reclassified as a case of defective or invalid promising rather than as a moral failure. This result is implausible. We ordinarily judge that promises can be

validly made even when they are later broken, and that such failures are appropriate targets of blame or criticism.

By tying the validity of a promise to prior knowledge, KP threatens to excuse promise-breaking rather than explain it. The norm therefore mischaracterizes the moral significance of promising and its violation. This provides a further reason to reject KP as an adequate norm of promising.

IV. Promising and Epistemic Improvement

So far, I have assumed that the Epistemic Improvement Principle is a genuine principle and have argued that KP cannot accommodate this principle within its own framework and is therefore forced to reject it. I now propose an account of the reasons generated by promising that treats the Epistemic Improvement of Promising as genuine, by appealing to the reasons that a promise itself creates for the promisor.

First, it is worth noting that if ϕ -ing is obligatory for an agent, then the agent has an obligation to keep ϕ as an available option for herself until the obligation is satisfied. This can be illustrated by the following case. Suppose that you promise your friend to be at a Café at 8 o'clock. In that case, you ought not to go to the stadium to watch a football match that also starts at 8, even if you would prefer watching the match, since going to the stadium would make it impossible for you to fulfill your promise to be at the café.

In addition, let me explain my understanding of what it is to be in a position to know P. Roughly speaking, one may have several reasons in favor of knowing P, as well as reasons against knowing P. Suppose that, at an initial stage, one has a reason in favor of knowing P, and that at a later stage one acquire an additional reason against knowing P. In that case, I take one's earlier position to be epistemically better with respect to knowing P than the later one.⁴ More generally, this suggests that the fewer reasons one has against P, the better one is positioned to know P.

Now return to the case mentioned above concerning going to the stadium while you promised. What the example is meant to show is that if one has an obligation to ϕ , one also has an obligation to keep ϕ -ing as an available option. I take this obligation to be discharged by preventing certain

⁴ Here, I focus only on the direction of reasons, not on their relative strength. So, I suppose same strength for every reasons I discuss.

facts from functioning as reasons in one's deliberation⁵. In this case, the promise prevents the fact that one prefers to go to the stadium from counting as a reason against ϕ . As a result, one has fewer reasons against ϕ -ing, and, as I have explained, one is thereby in a better position to know that one will ϕ . In other words, it is precisely the prevention of a potential reason against ϕ -ing places the agent in a better epistemic position with respect to ϕ .⁶ What motivates this view is that if one rejects the preventive account and instead hold that the excluded considerations remain a genuine reason against ϕ -ing, then one must say that, even when an agent fulfills her promise, she does so while failing to appropriately care to a reason against ϕ -ing. This implies that, although the agent does what she promised, she nevertheless acts wrongly in favor of not caring to that reason, which is the implausible result.

V. The Absurdity of Moorean Promises

I have argued for the Epistemic Improvement of the promisor with respect to knowing ϕ when one has promised, and I now explain how this principle helps to account for the absurdity of Moorean promises. First, by promising, one not only undertakes an obligation to do what one promised, but also undertakes an obligation to keep one's promise. Moreover, I take keeping one's promise to involve preventing certain facts from functioning as reasons in one's deliberation, exactly as in the case discussed earlier concerning going to the café or the stadium.

Second, I take promising to have several implications. I don't intend to address all of them here; rather, I focus specifically on the epistemic commitment implied by a promise. When one promises, one implies that one will keep one's promise, and this implication is a necessary feature of promising. In other words, there is no promise that lacks the implication of keeping the promise. I further hold that the implication of keeping a promise is the implication of a commitment to preventing certain facts from counting as reasons in the promisor's deliberation. Thus, in promising, one implies that one will exclude some potential considerations from counting against ϕ -ing, and this is essential to the practice of promising. By contrast, when one asserts that one does

⁵ I borrow this preventive mechanism from Benjamin Kiesewetter, "Exclusionary Reasons and the Balancing View of Oughts," forthcoming in *Oxford Studies in Metaethics*, vol. 21 (2026).

⁶ On my account, the reasons generated by promising have a dual role. The normative reason that grounds the obligation to ϕ also plays an epistemic role by improving the agent's position with respect to knowing that she will ϕ .

not know that one will ϕ , one implies that one's epistemic position with respect to ϕ after promising is no different from one's epistemic position before promising. This implication is incompatible with the Epistemic Improvement of Promising.

Thus, what makes the Moorean promises absurd is that they involve undertaking a commitment that characteristically improves one's epistemic position, while simultaneously denying that the improvement has taken place.

VI. Conclusion

In this paper, I have examined the apparent absurdity of Moorean promises and evaluated an influential explanation of the phenomenon based on the Knowledge Norm of Promising. While this norm captures an important aspect of our intuitive reaction to Moorean promises, I argued that it does so at the cost of rendering many ordinary promises defective and distorting the normative structure of promising. In particular, KP fails as both a necessary and a sufficient condition on promising and yields implausible consequences concerning promise-breaking.

I proposed an alternative account according to which promising itself brings about an epistemic improvement. By undertaking a promise, the promisor commits to excluding certain considerations from deliberation, thereby placing herself in a better position to know that she will act as promised. This account preserves the normative significance of promising while avoiding the overly demanding epistemic requirements imposed by KP.

On this view, Moorean promises are absurd not because they violate an external epistemic norm, but because they involve undertaking a commitment whose characteristic epistemic upshot is immediately denied. This explanation captures the distinctive oddness of Moorean promises while remaining faithful to our ordinary practices of promising.

References

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